

accused of being involved in former premier Benazir Bhutto's assassination, purportedly accepted his involvement in the three most recent attacks—the third occurring on army personnel in Frontier province's Bannu district—in a call to a Pushto language radio station. In the alleged

greater involvement in both countries. It has called for more American and NATO troops in Afghanistan to combat a strengthening Taliban insurgency at the same time indicating a willingness to negotiate with 'moderate elements' within it.

The change of American strategy is also reflected in the US policy towards Pakistan, where containing militancy within the country is now seen by US advisers as critical to US interests in the region. Because of its much larger population, its large standing army, economic troubles, and its possession of nuclear weapons, many American think tanks have dubbed 'stabilising' Pakistan as 'even more important' than making Afghanistan peaceful. The new US thinking is partly reflected in its growing reconciliation with former premier Nawaz Sharif, whose closeness to the religious parties is now seen as useful for influencing 'moderate' Islamists to counter hardline elements.

The Pakistan Government has welcomed the American pledge for greater financial

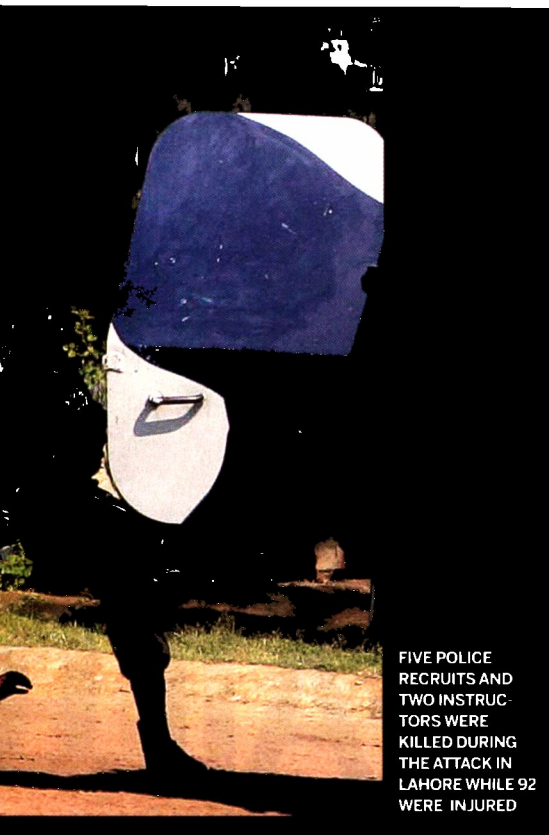
assistance—over \$10 billion has been promised to Pakistan over the next five years, three-fourths of it for non-military programmes—but has also expressed its unease that the aid has been tied to "greater cooperation" by Pakistan in the war against Al Qaeda and the Taliban. It fears that the American linkage will be used to pressure Pakistan to take further unpopular military actions that would undermine the much-needed domestic support for curbing militancy. "Pakistan has already done enough."

Prime Minister Yousuf Raza Gilani told reporters in Islamabad. "Pakistani security forces have suffered more casualties than the NATO forces. We have to go for three Ds—Dialogue, Development and Deterrence. How can you win the hearts and minds of the people with a military solution only?"

There is also disquiet among the establishment over what it sees as a "concerted campaign to weaken the Pakistan Army." The recent statements made by US officials such as US Armed Forces Chief Admiral Mike Mullen, Centcom Chief General David Petraeus and Special Envoy Richard Holbrooke, to US media networks, have set off alarm bells in Pakistan. The Americans have squarely accused the Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) of colluding with the Afghan Taliban and protecting them from US strikes. Denied by Pakistan as "a pack of lies", these accusations follow on the heels of a US media report—denied by the US administration—that the Americans were considering strikes in Balochistan's capital Quetta, which they consider a "safe haven for the Taliban leadership". There have also been calls within the US of expanding its Afghan theatre of operations to Pakistan.

Political analysts have mocked Admiral Mullen's statement that the ISI should "forget about Afghanistan and India" as an attempt to defang the country's intelligence services and make Pakistan subservient to interests of the United States and regional powers such as India. The ISI, on its part, sees itself as protecting Pakistani national interests "as much as other intelligence agencies protect their countries' interests", in the words of former President General Pervez Musharraf, who it seems has been entrusted with the task of publicising the Pakistan establishment's point of view.

Unfortunately for most Pakistanis, the war against militancy in Pakistan has become a choice between the devil and the deep blue sea. ■



FIVE POLICE RECRUITS AND TWO INSTRUCTORS WERE KILLED DURING THE ATTACK IN LAHORE WHILE 92 WERE INJURED

call, he warned that since President Asif Zardari had allowed American drone attacks to continue in the FATA areas, his men would continue to target government and law enforcement personnel all over Pakistan. He also threatened that he could, and would, target the White House in Washington if the attacks did not stop.

The warning has come only a couple of days after the announcement by US President Barack Obama of a policy review for Afghanistan and Pakistan which commits the US to